

The Hardest Story in the Bible (for me)

When I was young, the story of Joshua and the great Battle of Jericho was a popular one in Kid's Church. I even remember a Sunday church performance of the song "Joshua Fought the Battle of Jericho." No older than 12, I dressed in what we assumed were costumes fitting to what the Hebrew people would have worn after wandering in the desert for forty years (my white robe seems all too clean in hindsight), and we sang the song that was originally taught to most of us by a group of singing, Bible-loving vegetables.

I often thought back on that memory while studying this portion of the Bible. As I continued to read more of the book of Joshua, and the reality of what the stories were communicating to me became clear, I became, well, disturbed—if that's even the right word.

Because I can appreciate what this story, and how it was communicated, taught me, but it didn't feel complete. God is with us. God is on our side. (My side?) You cannot fail—or lose

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—when God is with you. Now, I wouldn't say these things are untrue, but it truly was distorted in my mind. And maybe you experienced something similar? It subconsciously led to an us-and-them worldview. One that told me very little, if anything, about God's love and desire for the individuals on the other side of the story—the other side of Jericho's walls, the nations Joshua and his armies later destroyed. Instead it

led to my private Christian high school sports teams praying for victory over the other—"God is on our side!"—while they very well could have been praying a very similar prayer in the locker room next door.

It led to the inherent belief that my church, my theological standpoint, my truth (which, of course, was God's truth, right?) was the correct one that would win out. Because, well, that's what he did for Joshua, right? The message I received through this song and the church lessons surrounding it became, "Be strong and courageous and you'll always be the winner!" When, in the context of the larger Story of God and His love for all creation, and His desire for all of us to partner with Him in caring for it, this doesn't seem like it is the pearl of wisdom we should be gleaning from this story. Winning at the expense of the lives of others? There must be more here.

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This all led me to a point of disgust, or that "disturbed" feeling when I looked back on the memory of singing "and the walls came a' tumbling down" on that Sunday morning decades ago. And I wasn't sure how to sit in the discomfort of this story and others like it.

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So I did some research about the song itself before diving into the context of the world of biblical Joshua. Some of you may already know this, but the song was written by enslaved African Americans in the early 1800s. It is an African American spiritual, a hymn. “Joshua Fought the Battle of Jericho” is a song written *by the oppressed for the oppressed*. A song that should capture the *za’aqah* of an enslaved people for generations.

These words (go look it up if you are unfamiliar) and the refrain “walls came tumbling down,” hit differently now that I’ve done more digging. I’m not trying to fix the problems I saw when I began to struggle with this song, but I am beginning to understand why it was written. The little girl in the bleached-white bedsheet robe under the lights on a church stage cannot begin to empathize with being under this sort of oppression, but she can try to understand and learn from it and let it transform how she views the original meaning and purpose of the song and the story upon which it was based.

Perhaps reading the actual story of Joshua in the Bible with this sort of openness and perspective of text and context is vital to how we wrestle with the most difficult of stories in this book? I cannot empathize with the children of Israel in this moment or the people the book says they destroyed, and I should be aware of that.

What do we do with the many problems we see? What would “be strong and courageous” have communicated to this next generation of Hebrew children, born into slavery or wandering their entire lives in the desert? What might God want them to remember about Him? This might then change our personal interpretations of the Text. In all honesty, I wrestle with my own life experience and question if I see myself in this Story more on the inside of Jericho’s walls than standing courageously behind Joshua. What might this sort of textual and historical awareness teach us? What might it have communicated to the oppressed, or even the oppressors, throughout history?

PRAYER

God,
May we lean in when the stories challenge us, pressing further into our questions.
May we not turn our face away from the Texts that make us uncomfortable, but seek to know you more.
May we create and be standing stones, reminding the world of what you have done, where we have come from, and all that you have taught us.
May we not look away, but be strong and courageous, quick to do the work you have given us to carry out, and encourage others to join us along the journey, even if we don’t see the full picture.

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

Take time to review: dig into the Text of Joshua beyond the battle of Jericho. What could you memorize or study more deeply? Why do they stand out as important to remember?



COMMUNITY

Think back to your group conversations, wherever they occurred. What makes you uncomfortable in this conversation? How might your group see differently?



DISCIPLESHIP

Is there anyone you're taking with you into these new places? This book is one that turns many young people away from God. "How could he?" Who could you invite into this space with you?



WRESTLING

What questions still remain after hearing from the BEMA team? What resonates with you? Angers or unsettles you still? How can you lean into this more?



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 2



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases that we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God. In Session 1, we encountered the idea of “Creating Space for God” in our lives. We believe that **if we do our part of creating that space, God will fill it** as He desires. You’re already doing this as you dive into the Text and jump into a place to discuss. God will meet you in these places! Look for places the Holy Spirit can do work in and through you as you go about your everyday life.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe that young adults are shaping the **future of this world**. Jesus modeled a ministry of discipling young adults, and that approach has and will work. If you are a college student who is listening, we want this material to be directly helpful to your pursuits. If you are not a college student, we want to challenge you to come alongside one and work together.*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn’t only for church or Bible study; this is about what we do every day. How we do our job and how it may take advantage of or bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world. Justice is very much something God cares about. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? Does it exploit creation? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can provide relief to others. **The work we do every day is sacred and matters!***